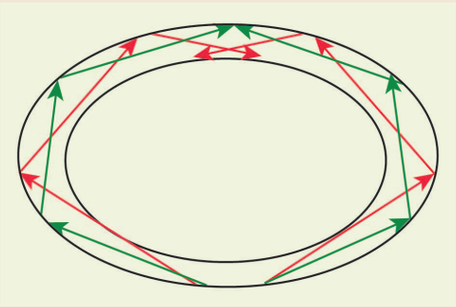
This principle is used in designing whispering halls. In a whispering hall, the speech of a person standing in one focus can be heard clearly by a listener standing at the other focus.

Whispering Gallery

One of the famous whispering galleries is in St. Paul's cathedral church in London. It is built with elliptically shaped walls. When a person is talking at one focus, his voice can be heard distinctly at the other focus. It is due to the multiple reflections of sound waves from the curved walls.



5.3 ECHOES

An echo is the sound reproduced due to the reflection of the original sound from various rigid surfaces such as walls, ceilings, surfaces of mountains, etc.

If you shout or clap near a mountain or near a reflecting surface, like a building you can hear the same sound again. The sound, which you hear is called an echo. It is due to the reflection of sound. One does not experience any echo sound in a small room. This does not mean that sound is not reflected in a small room. This is because smaller rooms do not satisfy the basic conditions for hearing an echo.

5.3.1 Conditions necessary for hearing echo

1. The persistence of hearing for human ears is 0.1 second. This means that you can hear two sound waves clearly, if the time interval between the two sounds is at least 0.1 s. Thus, the minimum time gap between the original sound and an echo must be 0.1 s.
2. The above criterion can be satisfied only when the distance between the source of sound and the reflecting surface would satisfy the following equation:

$$\text{Velocity} = \frac{\text{distance travelled by sound}}{\text{time taken}}$$

$$v = \frac{2d}{t}$$

$$d = \frac{vt}{2}$$

Since, t = 0.1 second, then $d = \frac{v \times 0.1}{2} = \frac{v}{20}$

Thus the minimum distance required to hear an echo is $1/20^{th}$ part of the magnitude of the velocity of sound in air. If you consider the velocity of sound as 344 ms^{-1}, the minimum distance required to hear an echo is 17.2 m.

5.3.2 Applications of echo

- Some animals communicate with each other over long distances and also locate objects by sending the sound signals and receiving the echo as reflected from the targets.
- The principle of echo is used in obstetric ultrasonography, which is used to create real-time visual images of the developing embryo or fetus in the mother's uterus. This is a safe testing tool, as it does not use any harmful radiations.
- Echo is used to determine the velocity of sound waves in any medium.

5.3.3 Measuring velocity of sound by echo method

Apparatus required:

A source of sound pulses, a measuring tape, a sound receiver, and a stop watch.

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